Day in the life - 'Always work to do' - Corry - Erie Times-News (PA) - March 29, 2026 - page A1
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A Day in the Life is a monthly series in which we highlight some of the area's more interesting jobs and how these people interact with the community.

Craig Lucas prepared for the 2026 trout stocking season with some yoga and physical therapy. Years of scooping nets filled with 25 pounds of floppy trout and lifting them to coworkers on a stocking truck has sparked lower back issues. "Every move we do is bad for your back," Lucas said with a laugh. "I have been doing some yoga and PT since January to help with my sciatica pain. It has really helped." Lucas, 46, has worked as the Corry State **Fish Hatchery** manager since 2021 and started his career with the Pennsylvania **Fish** & Boat Commission in 2002.

Though he spends part of each workday sitting behind a desk, answering emails and doing other administrative work, the job of running the 150-year-old **hatchery** keeps his hands scaly.

Six mornings a week from mid-February to mid-May, Lucas joins his staff to fill two stocking trucks.

The method hasn't changed in decades: Use large **fish** nets to scoop rainbow, brown and golden trout out of the **hatchery**'s linear outdoor raceways and pour them into the trucks' tanks.

"Since we start in mid-February, it's pretty cold some mornings," Lucas said. "When we get snow, we have to plow a path on each side of the raceway."

Some mornings the crew is supervised by Charlie, a bald eagle that lives near the **hatchery** and hangs out in the nearby woods. Charlie is given an occasional meal of the **hatchery**'s dead **fish**.

The raceways' water supply is temperature controlled and oxidized, so the trout remain outside throughout the year. The raceways also have roofs and netting along the sides.

"You can always tell when a net is down or there is an opening, because you will see a couple of large birds on the roof," Lucas said.

Hatchery employees have been raising **fish** on the 227-acre grounds since 1876. A small visitors center, which attracts about 5,000 people a year, displays photos of the old raceways and examples of the equipment Lucas' predecessors used.

"They would carry **fish** in backpacks and walk through the woods to stock some streams," Lucas said.

The Corry **hatchery**, one of 15 in the state, stocks trout in streams from Warren County south to near Pittsburgh. It raises about 330,000 trout annually that contribute to a $500 million a year statewide industry.

Those **fish** are raised at the **hatchery** from eggs or young fingerlings for a period of 18 months to three years before they are transported for stocking.

The youngest **fish** are kept in the hatch house, a building with large cement raceways that are probably 100 years old, Lucas said.

"We have about 14,000 **fish** in these tanks," Lucas said as he cleaned the tank with a brush as the small **fish** darted around it. "We clean these every day."

Lucas oversees staff of seven at **hatchery**

An avid fisherman and hunter whose office is filled with mounted deer skulls, Lucas earned a degree in fisheries and aquatic biology at Mansfield University in 2002.

Lucas simultaneously managed the hatcheries in Fairview Township and Tionesta before transferring to Corry. He oversees a staff that includes five **fish** culturists, a foreman and a clerk/typist.

"We have all worked at hatcheries for years, though I have a new worker coming who is in their 20s," Lucas said. "It will be good to have a young person with us."

Though trout stocking takes place primarily in the late winter and early spring, raising the **fish** is a year-round job.

"There is always work to do but I'd say summer is the slowest season for us," Lucas said. "That's when we do our improvement projects around the **hatchery**, like paint the hatch house tanks."

PA trout fishing thrives due to hatcheries

Lucas says he enjoys playing a role in the state's fishing industry. He pointed out that about 70% of

the eggs and fingerlings the **hatchery** receives live to be stocked in streams and creeks.

In the wild, only about 4% survive.

"If there was no stocking, there would still be some trout but it would be a shell of what we have now," Lucas said. "Some streams wouldn't have any at all."

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